

Week 8 – Workshop

Geothermics: Steady-State Heat Flow



Geophysics 3A: Potential Fields & Geothermics

July 22, 2026

Duration: 3 hours

Setting: Workshop room

Preparation

Pre-reading: Course Notes, Ch. 10

Lecture videos:

Notes:

Purpose

This workshop uses conservation-of-energy reasoning to build intuition for steady-state geotherms: how thermal conductivity contrasts refract isotherms and redistribute gradients, and how crustal heat production controls geotherm curvature and deep temperatures.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this workshop, students should be able to:

- Use conservation of energy to reason about steady-state geotherms.
- Explain how thermal conductivity contrasts redistribute isotherms.
- Interpret geotherm curvature in terms of crustal heat production.
- Relate conductivity and heat production variations to geothermal potential.

Session Flow (170 min)

0–15 min: Warm-up — Thermal Refraction

Compare two crustal columns with identical basal heat flow:

- Case A: crystalline crust exposed at the surface.
- Case B: crystalline crust overlain by a low-conductivity sedimentary layer.

In this activity, you'll look at how temperature, thermal gradient and heat flow are affected by the presence of a sedimentary basin.

15–30 min: Mini-lecture — Conceptual Framing

- Steady-state heat flow as an energy bookkeeping problem.
- Review Fourier's law and the meaning of heat flow.
- Emphasize the separation of roles:
 - conductivity controls *gradients*,
 - heat production controls *curvature*.

Geological Discussion

- Implications for geothermal gradients measured in boreholes.
- Relative geothermal potential of sedimentary basins vs exposed cratons.

30–65 min: Activity 8.A: Conductivity Anisotropy

Anisotropy in conductivity manifests from structural arrangement of two or more materials. It can happen in layered rocks or layered sequences of rocks. We'll explore the mathematical theory that gives rise to anisotropy and look at the anisotropy in several metamorphic hand samples.

65–70 min: Break

70–105 min: Activity 8.B: Energy Conservation and Geotherm Curvature

Central Question How can two terranes with identical surface heat flow have different Moho temperatures?

Steps

- Write the energy balance:

$$q_0 = q_b + \int_0^{z_c} A(z) dz$$

- Infer relative crustal heat production given different basal inputs.
- Introduce the steady-state solution and the curvature term:

$$T(z) = T_0 + \frac{q_0}{k} z - \frac{A}{2k} z^2$$

Curvature differences imply different deep temperatures even when surface gradients match.

105–140 min: Activity 8.C: Why Is Archean Heat Production So Low?

Observation Decay alone predicts high early heat production, yet preserved Archean crust shows limits.

Guided Discussion Topics

- Differentiation and partitioning of LILEs (K, Th, U).
- Selective erosion of felsic upper crust.
- Reworking: remelting and redistribution of older crust.
- Foundering of dense mafic roots.
- Secular mantle thermal evolution.

140–160 min: Wrap-up

- Summarize roles of k and A .
- Connect observations to upcoming steady-state problem set.

160–170 min: Preview: Transient Heat Flow

So far we have assumed that temperature does not change with time—a useful idealization for mature, stable terranes. But many geologically interesting situations involve heat flow that evolves: cooling of the oceanic lithosphere, heating around a magmatic intrusion, or the thermal relaxation of a thrust belt. Next week we move to transient heat conduction, governed by the diffusion equation, and develop the concept of thermal diffusivity as the quantity that controls how quickly temperature anomalies propagate through rock.

Workshop Notes

Workshop Notes

Activity 8.A

Thermal Refraction

Purpose

To build intuition for how low-conductivity surface layers redistribute temperature gradients without changing the total heat flow.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

- Apply Fourier's law to explain why the temperature gradient differs between regions with constant heat flow.
- Sketch temperature–depth profiles for a layered crust and identify where isotherms are compressed or stretched.
- Predict which crustal section reaches higher interface temperatures and explain why.
- Discuss how varying conductivity affects geothermal energy potential.

Geological Context

Consider two continental regions with identical basal heat flow (Figure 1):

Region A: crystalline crust exposed at the surface.

Region B: crystalline crust overlain by a thick sedimentary basin.

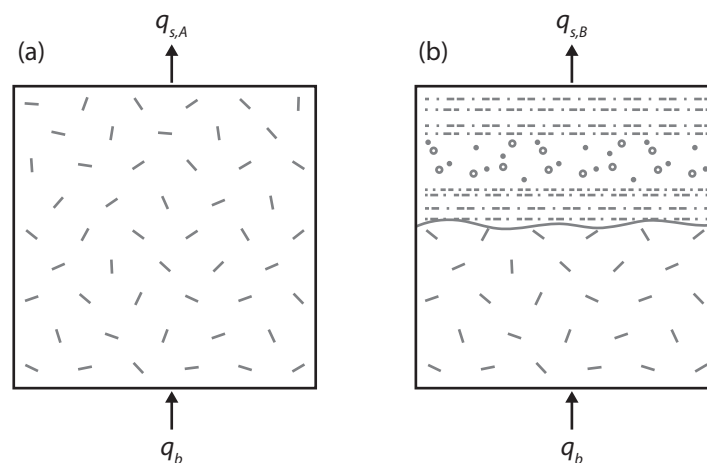


Figure 1: Two continental regions: (a) igneous crust, (b) sedimentary basin over igneous crust. Both regions have the same basal heat flow.

The sediments are dominated by shales and porous clastic rocks with lower thermal conductivity than basement rock. We will make the following assumptions:

- no internal heat production,
- steady-state heat flow, and
- heat flow is vertical and laterally uniform.

Tasks

Question 1. Reasoning

What is the relationship between the surface heat flow of regions A and B? What principle did you use to make this determination?

Using Fourier's law,

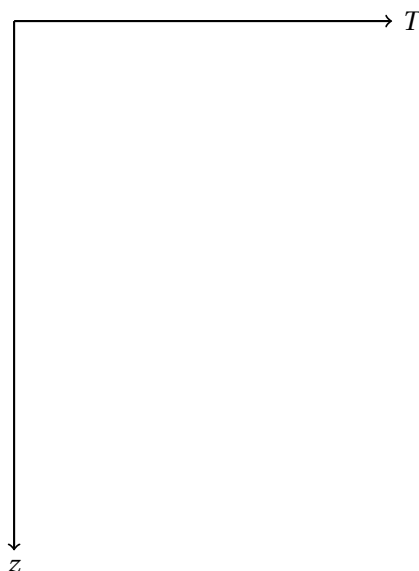
$$q = -k \frac{dT}{dz},$$

explain qualitatively how the temperature gradient differs between the sedimentary basin and the igneous basement?

Question 2. Sketch

Sketch temperature versus depth for both regions on the same axes. Clearly label:

- sediment thickness,
- basement,
- relative steepness of gradients.



Question 3. Explanation & Discussion

- Which region would exhibit a higher temperature at the sediment–basement interface?

Explain why.

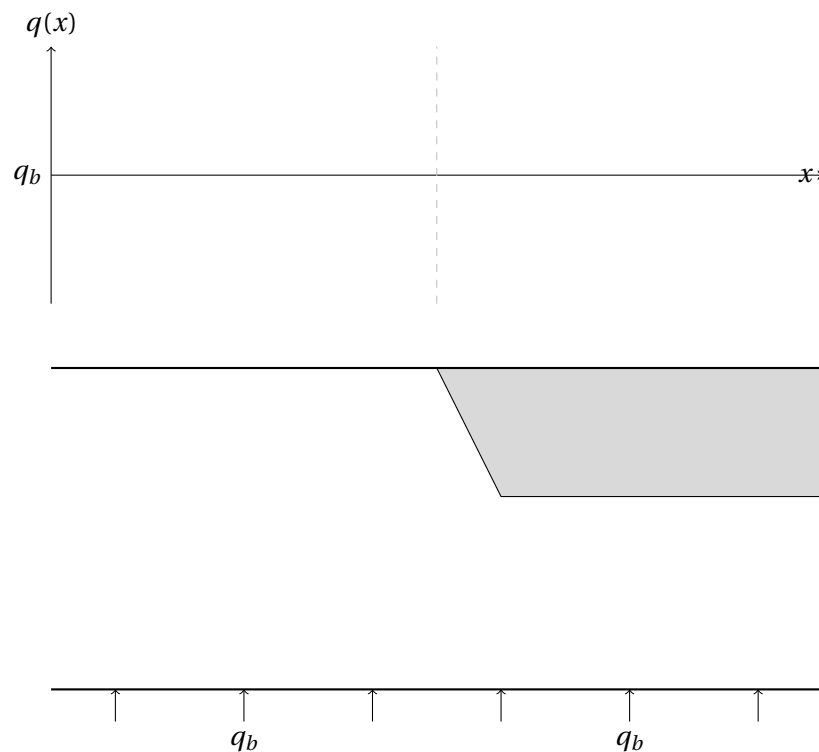
ii How does the presence of sediments affect measured geothermal gradients?

iii Which region would you expect to have higher geothermal potential? Why?

Question 4. Extension

If these two regions were adjacent to each other, how would heat flow and temperature vary in 2D?

Start by drawing the heat flow lines, then the isotherms and finally the variation in surface heat flow on the axes provided.



Key Ideas

A conductivity contrast redistributes the gradient, not the flux. Whenever q must stay constant across a boundary but k changes, $dT/dz = -q/k$ forces the gradient to change instead. This effect is thermal refraction, and it applies at any conductivity contrast, not only a sediment-over-basement boundary – the same reasoning will reappear for layered media, tilted strata, and mixed lithologies.

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A measured gradient reflects local conductivity, not the deeper structure. The same heat flow can correspond to very different gradients depending on what you're measuring through, so gradients from different settings are not directly comparable without calculation of heat flow. A gradient measured near the surface is only converted to a true heat flow once you know the conductivity at the depth it was measured.

Activity 8.B

Layered and Anisotropic Conductivity

Purpose

To see how anisotropy of thermal conductivity arises from simple geometric models of layered materials and how this is expressed in natural samples.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

- Derive the effective conductivity of layered media when heat flows parallel or perpendicular to layering.
- Use real directional conductivity data to estimate an anisotropy factor and propose a functional form for how conductivity varies with angle.

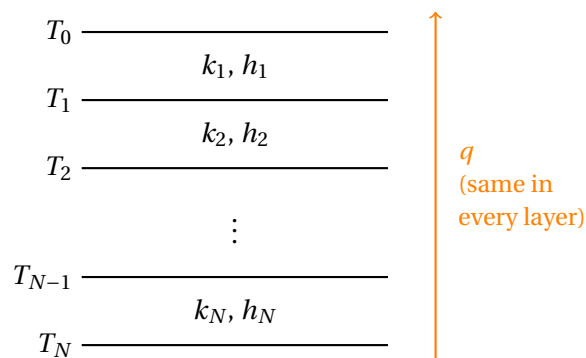
Geological Context

Layering can happen in many geological contexts and at all scales from sheets of mica to layers in a sedimentary basin. This activity builds the theoretical bounds on that directional dependence, then checks them against real measurements.

Tasks

Question 1. Perpendicular Case: Heat Flow Across the Layering

Consider N layers stacked with heat flowing perpendicular to the layering – crossing every layer in turn, exactly as in Activity 8.A, but now for an arbitrary number of layers rather than two. Layer i has thickness h_i and conductivity k_i ; the interface temperatures are T_0 (top) through T_N (base), and $H = \sum_i h_i$.



- (a) In steady state with no internal heat production, what must be true about q at every interface between layers, and why?

- (b) Heat flows upward, from T_N at the base toward T_0 at the top, so $T_N > T_0$: temperature increases with depth. Write Fourier's law for the temperature drop $\Delta T_i = T_i - T_{i-1}$ across layer i alone (positive, since the deeper interface is hotter), in terms of q , k_i , and h_i .

- (c) The total drop across the whole stack, in the direction heat is flowing, is $\Delta T = T_N - T_0$. How does ΔT relate to the individual ΔT_i ?

- (d) Combine (b) and (c) to write ΔT as a single sum over all N layers.

- (e) Define an effective conductivity $k_\perp$ by requiring the whole stack obey Fourier's law as if it were one layer: $\Delta T = qH/k_\perp$. Set this equal to your result from (d) and solve for $1/k_\perp$.

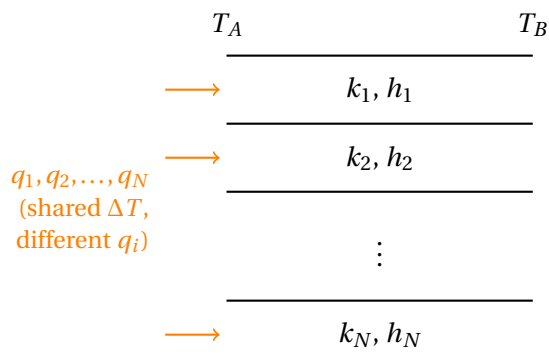
You should arrive at

$$\frac{1}{k_\perp} = \sum_{i=1}^N \frac{f_i}{k_i}, \quad f_i \equiv \frac{h_i}{H}. \quad (1)$$

This is the thickness-weighted *harmonic mean* – the same result as for two layers, but it fell out of the derivation for arbitrary N with no extra work, since the sum in (d) was already general.

Question 2. Parallel Case: Heat Flow Along the Layering

Now consider the *same* stack of layers, but with heat flowing along the layering instead – parallel to strike, not across it. Each layer independently carries its own share of the heat flow between two shared end temperatures T_A and T_B .



- (a) What quantity is now shared by every layer – not q this time, but something else? (Compare to part (a) of Question 1: there, q was forced to be equal across every layer. What plays that role here?)

- (b) Heat flows from T_A toward T_B , so $T_A > T_B$. Write Fourier's law for the heat flow q_i carried by layer i , in terms of the shared gradient $g = (T_A - T_B)/\Delta x$ (positive, in the direction heat is flowing) and k_i .

- (c) Each layer contributes $q_i h_i$ (its flux times its own thickness) to the total heat flow through the stack's cross-section. Write Q_{total} as a sum over all N layers.

- (d) Define $k_{\parallel}$ by requiring the whole stack carry $Q_{\text{total}} = k_{\parallel} g H$. Solve for $k_{\parallel}$.

You should arrive at

$$k_{\parallel} = \sum_{i=1}^N f_i k_i, \quad (2)$$

the thickness-weighted *arithmetic mean* – and notice this one required no manipulation of reciprocals at all; the sum was already in the right form from step (c).

Question 3. Numeric Check

A layered sequence has the properties below.

Layer	1	2	3	4
h_i (m)	12	4	20	8
k_i ($\text{W m}^{-1}\text{K}^{-1}$)	1.2	7.0	1.5	5.0

- (a) Compute $k_{\perp}$ (perpendicular, across-layering) for this sequence.

- (b) Compute $k_{\parallel}$ (parallel, along-layering) for the same sequence.

- (c) Which is larger? By roughly what factor?

- (d) This ordering, $k_{\parallel} \geq k_{\perp}$, holds for *any* set of positive k_i – it's the arithmetic-mean/harmonic-mean inequality, a general mathematical fact, not a coincidence of these numbers. Physically, why should heat flowing *along* the layering always manage a higher effective conductivity than heat forced *across* it? (Hint: think about how much choice the heat has in each case about which layers carry it.)

Question 4. Real Data: Directional Conductivity in Foliated Rocks

Many metamorphic rocks develop a strong planar fabric—foliation—during deformation, aligning platy minerals (especially micas) into a preferred orientation.

The figure below shows measured thermal conductivity versus the angle between the measurement direction and foliation, for four samples: three metapelites and one gneiss.

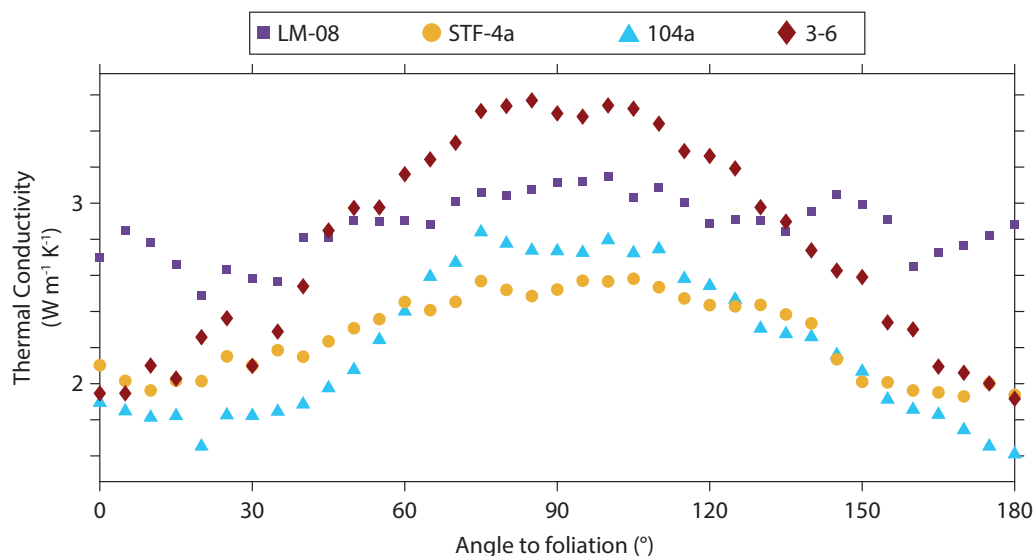


Figure 2: Thermal conductivity vs. angle to foliation for three metapelites and one gneiss.

- (a) At 0° , is the measurement direction along the foliation plane or across it? What about 90° ? State your reasoning – don't just guess the convention.

- (b) Using your answer to (a) together with Questions 1 and 2, which angle should correspond to $k_{\parallel}$ and which to $k_{\perp}$?

- (c) Does the real data fall between the bounds you'd expect, or does something surprise you? Where do the curves peak?

- (d) Define the **anisotropy factor** as $A = k_{\max}/k_{\min}$ for a given sample. Estimate A for each of the four samples by reading approximate maximum and minimum conductivities off the figure.

- (e) Compare A across the three metapelites and the one gneiss. Is one rock type consistently more anisotropic than the other? Suggest a reason, connected to how each rock's fabric actually formed.

- (f) Propose a simple mathematical function $k(\theta)$ that (i) equals your two derived bounds at the two extreme angles, and (ii) varies smoothly in between. You don't need to fit it precisely – just propose a reasonable functional form and justify why you chose it.

Key Ideas

The same physical setup gives different effective properties depending on flow direction. Heat flowing across layering shares the same flux and sums temperature drops (harmonic mean); heat flowing along layering shares the same gradient and sums fluxes (arithmetic mean). Recognizing *which quantity is common* to every layer is the whole derivation – the mean falls out mechanically once that's identified.

Parallel flow can always exploit the fastest pathway; perpendicular flow cannot avoid the slowest one. $k_{\parallel} \geq k_{\perp}$ always, because along-layering heat is free to concentrate disproportionately in the highest-conductivity layers, while across-layering heat has no choice but to cross every layer, including the most resistive one, at the same rate as all the others.

Real anisotropic media are not obligated to sit inside an idealized two-direction bound. The harmonic/arithmetic bracket comes from treating a rock as alternating layers of two conductivities. Real foliated rocks carry additional anisotropy from the crystal-scale conductivity of their constituent minerals, so the true directional dependence is a combination of layering geometry and mineral fabric, not layering geometry alone.

Activity 8.C

Estimating Crustal Heat Production from Seismic Velocity

Purpose

Thermal conductivity can be measured directly on a hand sample, and gravity, magnetics, and seismic velocity can all be estimated remotely at depth. Heat production cannot – there is no field survey that tells you $A(z)$ directly. This activity asks whether seismic velocity, which *can* be estimated at depth almost everywhere, can stand in as a proxy for heat production, which can't. It can, to a real and useful degree – but pushing that proxy all the way to a testable prediction exposes a genuine, unresolved tension between two entirely reasonable ways of estimating the same quantity.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

- Explain why heat production is harder to estimate at depth than density, susceptibility, or resistivity.
- Evaluate a real scientific critique of a proposed geophysical proxy relationship, and identify when a change of variable (not new data) resolves it.
- Use real velocity-depth data and an empirical velocity-heat production relationship to estimate a terrane's radiogenic crustal heat flow.
- Test that estimate against an independent constraint – conservation of energy – and reason about which of two disagreeing methods deserves more trust, and why.

Geological Context

Density, magnetic susceptibility, electrical resistivity, and seismic velocity can all, in principle, be estimated at depth from a surface survey – that is the entire premise of applied geophysics. Heat production cannot: it has no directly observable geophysical field of its own. Rybach and Čermák proposed a workaround decades ago – since seismic velocity depends on bulk mineralogy and heat production depends on trace radioactive element concentrations, and both broadly track a rock's felsic-to-mafic character, velocity might serve as an indirect proxy for heat production, remotely sensed the way heat production itself cannot be.

Fountain (1986) pushed back hard: plotted directly, A against V_p is extremely scattered – visually close to no relationship at all. This activity works through both Fountain's objection and a resolution to it, using two Australian terranes with very different histories: the **Macquarie Arc**, a Palaeozoic magmatic arc within the Lachlan Orogen, and the **Yilgarn Craton**, an Archean shield.

Tasks

Question 1. Linear or Log? Revisiting Fountain's Critique

Below is measured heat production plotted against P-wave velocity for both terranes, first in linear space, then in $\log_{10}$ space with the fitted relationship $\log_{10} A = m_0(V_p - 6.0) + m_1$ overlaid.

- (a) Looking only at Figure 3, would you say Fountain had a point?

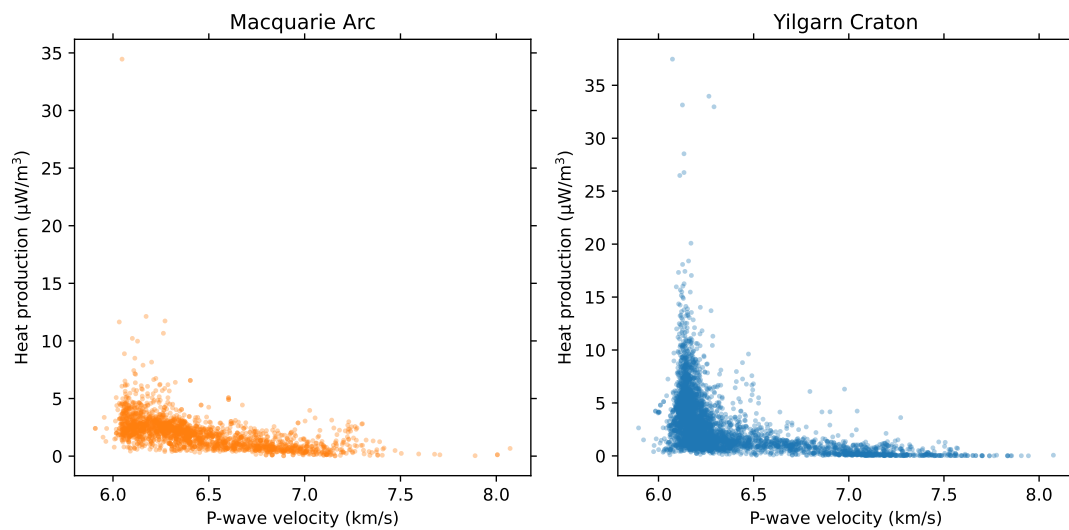


Figure 3: Heat production vs. V_p , linear space – Macquarie Arc and Yilgarn Craton.

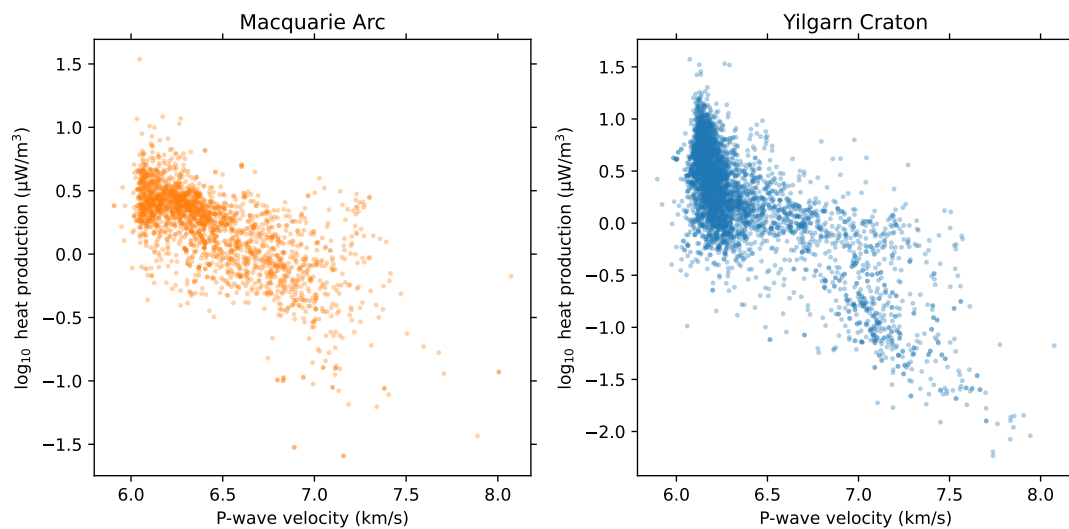


Figure 4: $\log_{10} A$ vs. V_p , same data, with the fitted terrane-specific relationships.

- (b) Now look at Figure 4. Has the underlying data changed, or just how it's displayed?

- (c) Heat production is approximately log-normally distributed. Why would that fact alone explain why the same data looks convincing in one space and hopeless in the other?

Question 2. Universal Relationship?

The two terranes' fitted relationships are:

$$\text{Macquarie Arc: } \log_{10} A = -0.727 (V_p - 6.0) + 0.551, \quad \text{Yilgarn Craton: } \log_{10} A = -1.193 (V_p - 6.0) + 0.695.$$

- (a) Which terrane's heat production is more sensitive to velocity – that is, which has the steeper slope?

- (b) The global fit across all measured terranes gives a slope of -0.888 , between these two. Is "one global relationship" a good description of what's actually going on, or is it closer to an average of many genuinely different local relationships?

Question 3. Does Sample Size Matter?

Fountain's original critique was based on a global compilation. The figure below shows r^2 against sample size N for 322 well-constrained terranes worldwide.

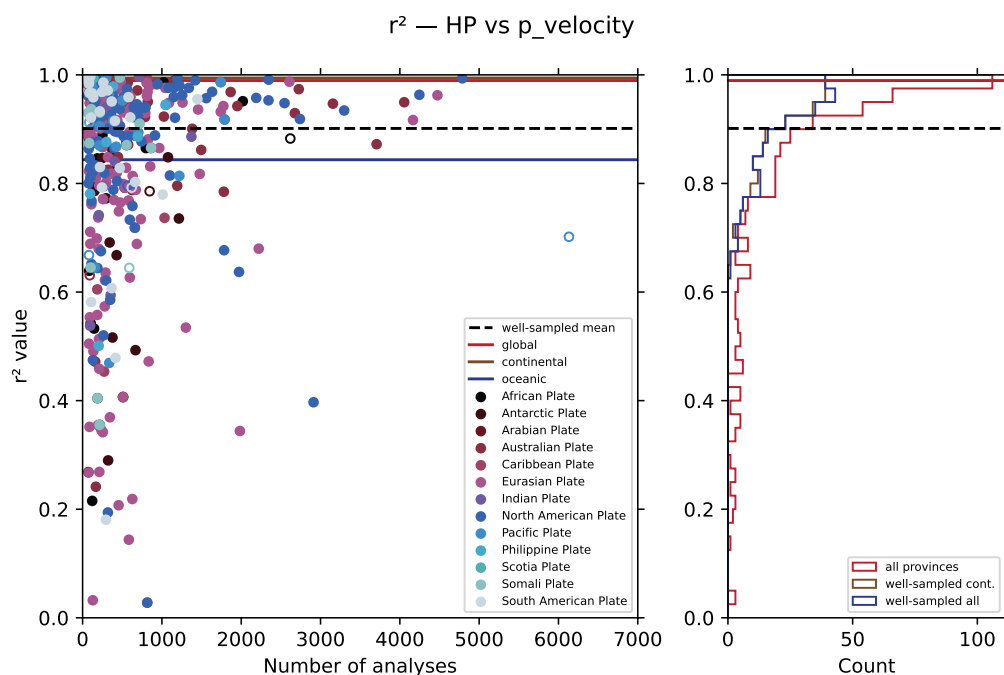


Figure 5: Goodness of fit (r^2) vs. sample size, across 322 terranes.

- (a) Describe the shape of this plot. Does the scatter in r^2 stay constant as N grows, or change?

- (b) If Fountain's compilation included many terranes with only a handful of samples each, how might that alone have made the relationship look weaker than it really is, without any of the log-space issue from Question 1?

Question 4. From Velocity to Heat Production

Table 1 gives median V_p in 5 km depth bins for both terranes, from a real crustal velocity model (AuSREM). For each bin, you will convert V_p into a heat production estimate and accumulate it into a crustal radiogenic heat flow.

Working in $\log_{10}$ space is faster: compute

$$\log_{10} A = m_0(V_p - 6.0) + m_1$$

first, then

$$A = 10^{\log_{10} A},$$

then multiply by the bin's thickness Δz (in km) to get that bin's contribution to heat flow, in mW/m^2 — the units work out directly, with no conversion factor needed, because $1 \mu\text{W m}^{-3} \times 1 \text{ km} = 1 \text{ mW m}^{-2}$.

Worked example (first row, Macquarie Arc): at $V_p = 6.02$,

$$\log_{10} A = -0.727(6.02 - 6.0) + 0.551 = 0.537,$$

so

$$A = 10^{0.537} = 3.44 \mu\text{W m}^{-3}.$$

Over the 5 km bin, this contributes $3.44 \times 5 = 17.2 \text{ mW m}^{-2}$. The Yilgarn Craton row is done the same way, using its own m_0 and m_1 .

- (a) Complete the table: fill in $\log_{10} A$, A , and each bin's contribution, then sum each terrane's column to get $q_{\text{rad,median}}$.

Table 1: P-wave velocity statistics by depth interval for each terrane.

Depth	N	V_p			$\log_{10} A$	A
		Median	Mean	Std		
km		km s^{-1}				
<i>Macquarie Arc</i>						
0–5	87	6.02	5.91	0.28	$-0.727(6.02 - 6.0) + 0.551 = 0.537$	$10^{0.537} = 3.44$
5–10	87	6.18	6.16	0.13		
10–15	87	6.31	6.32	0.13		
15–20	87	6.47	6.48	0.11		
20–25	87	6.62	6.63	0.09		
25–30	87	6.87	6.87	0.10		
30–35	86	7.10	7.10	0.13		
35–39.2	81	7.49	7.47	0.29		
40–42.6	48	7.65	7.63	0.25		
						$q_{\text{rad}} =$
<i>Yilgarn Craton</i>						
0–5	256	6.04	6.03	0.20	$-1.193(6.04 - 6.0) + 0.695 = 0.647$	$10^{0.647} = 4.436$
5–10	256	6.13	6.16	0.15	0.540	3.47
10–15	256	6.33	6.32	0.16	0.301	2.00
15–20	253	6.54	6.53	0.13	0.051	1.24
20–25	253	6.67	6.72	0.18	-0.104	0.787
25–30	253	6.94	6.98	0.20	-0.426	0.375
30–34.7	252	7.32	7.36	0.29	-0.880	0.132
35–38.3	184	7.79	7.81	0.20	-1.44	0.036
40–41.8	73	7.88	7.90	0.16	-1.55	0.028
						$q_{\text{rad}} =$

- (b) Which terrane's crustal column contributes more heat flow by this estimate? Does that match what you'd have predicted from the slopes in Question 2 alone, or does the shape of the velocity profile with depth also matter?

Question 5. The Log-Normal Correction

The fitted relationship predicts the *median* A at a given V_p – but *heat production* is an additive, volumetric quantity, so the physically relevant value for the integral you just computed is the *mean*, not the median. Because A is log-normally distributed, the mean is always larger than the median, by a factor

$$K \approx 10^{1.151\sigma_{10}^2},$$

where σ_{10} is the scatter of $\log_{10} A$ about the fitted line. Measured directly from each terrane's own data: $\sigma_{10} = 0.247$ ($K = 1.175$) for Macquarie Arc, and $\sigma_{10} = 0.342$ ($K = 1.364$) for Yilgarn Craton.

- (a) Multiply your two sums from Question 4 by the appropriate K to get the corrected, mean-based radiogenic heat flow estimate for each terrane.

Yilgarn Craton: mW m^{-2} Macquarie Arc: mW m^{-2}

- (b) Which terrane's estimate changed more in absolute terms? Why, given the two K values?

Question 6. A Paradox?

Real heat flow measurements exist for both terranes.

	Sites	Mean observed q (mW m^2)	Median observed q (mW m^2)
Macquarie Arc	48	71.2	70.3
Yilgarn Craton	66	37.8	37.1

In steady state, observed heat flow is the sum of everything generated in the crust above the measurement plus whatever is still arriving from the mantle: $q_{\text{observed}} = q_{\text{rad}} + q_{\text{mantle}}$, so $q_{\text{mantle}} = q_{\text{observed}} - q_{\text{rad}}$.

- (a) For each terrane, using your corrected (mean-based) q_{rad} from Question 5, compute the implied mantle heat flow q_{mantle} .

- (b) Is either result physically possible? What would a negative q_{mantle} actually mean?

- (c) Two independent, individually reasonable methods – a velocity-based proxy calibrated against real rock samples, and a direct energy-conservation argument – disagree here, sometimes severely. Which do you trust more, and why? What does each method actually depend on that the other doesn't?

- (d) This activity opened by asking whether heat production could be estimated the way density, susceptibility, or resistivity can be. Having worked through this, what's your answer now – and what, specifically, makes heat production harder?

Key Ideas

A relationship can be real and still look like noise, if you're looking in the wrong space. Fountain's critique wasn't wrong about what he saw – linear-space $A-V_p$ data genuinely is scattered. It was wrong about what that scatter meant, because it didn't account for heat production's log-normal distribution.

An empirical proxy relationship is only as trustworthy as the data used to build it – and it can be genuinely strong without being universal. Different terranes show different, real, well-constrained slopes; treating any single fit (even the well-supported global one) as a universal law discards information the data itself is offering.

When two independently-motivated methods disagree, ask what each one is actually constrained by. A velocity-based proxy is constrained only by the rock samples used to calibrate it – nothing stops it from predicting an impossible total. An energy-conservation argument is constrained by the whole system having to balance, and cannot produce a physically impossible answer without signalling that fact directly, as a negative flux. That asymmetry, not just "geophysics being more careful," is why the energy-balance constraint deserves more trust when the two disagree.

Activity 8.D

Building a Geotherm

Purpose

Every steady-state geotherm you have interpreted so far in this workshop – the refraction problem, the layered/anisotropic conductivity problem, the velocity-based heat production estimate – has depended on a geotherm existing without ever building one from scratch. This activity does that: given $k(z)$, $A(z)$, a surface temperature T_0 , and a surface heat flow q_0 , you will construct a full steady-state geotherm by hand, in two separate stages, and follow it all the way to the mantle adiabat.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

- List the ingredients needed to compute a steady-state geotherm, and identify which equation needs which of them.
- Compute $q(z)$ and $T(z)$ using a two-stage piecewise method, and explain why $q(z)$ can be completed before $T(z)$ is ever touched.
- Interpret the depth at which a conductive geotherm meets the mantle adiabat as the base of the thermal lithosphere.
- Predict and explain how changes in k and in A reshape a geotherm differently – including a case where *more* heat production produces *lower* temperatures.

Geological Context

Two equations govern a 1-D steady-state geotherm. Conservation of energy, with no lateral heat flow and no time-dependence:

$$\frac{dq}{dz} = -A(z) \quad \Rightarrow \quad q(z) = q_0 - \int_0^z A(z') dz'.$$

Fourier's law, relating the local gradient to the local heat flow and conductivity:

$$\frac{dT}{dz} = \frac{q(z)}{k(z)} \quad \Rightarrow \quad T(z) = T_0 + \int_0^z \frac{q(z')}{k(z')} dz'.$$

Notice that the first equation involves only $A(z)$ and q_0 – not k or T . The second equation needs $q(z)$, which means it cannot be started until the first is finished. That ordering is not a computational convenience; it is a real physical fact about which quantities depend on which.

Assuming a layered Earth within which the properties thermal conductivity and heat production are constant, we can write these as

$$q_{i+1} = q_i - A_{i+1}(z_{i+1} - z_i),$$

and

$$T_{i+1} = T_i + \frac{q_i}{k_i + 1}(z_{i+1} - z_i) - \frac{A_{i+1}}{2k_i + 1}(z_{i+1} - z_i)^2,$$

where i denotes the layer. Note that temperature and heat flow are determined at the top and bottom of and the physical properties are defined within each layer.

Deep enough, a conductive geotherm will meet the **mantle adiabat**, which can be approximated as $T = 1300 + 0.3z$ (z in km, T in °C). The temperature profile mantle material follows once convection, not conduction, controls how heat moves. The depth of that crossing marks the base of the thermal lithosphere.

Tasks

Question 1. The Recipe

- (a) From the two equations above, list everything you need to know before you can compute a geotherm.

- (b) Which of those quantities does $q(z)$ actually depend on? Which does $T(z)$ depend on that $q(z)$ does not?

Question 2. Stage 1: Building $q(z)$

A crustal column has the layers below. Take $q_0 = 60 \text{ mW/m}^2$ and $T_0 = 0^\circ\text{C}$.

Layer	Depth range (km)	k ($\text{W m}^{-1}\text{K}^{-1}$)	A ($\mu\text{W m}^{-3}$)
upper crust	0–15	3.0	1.5
lower crust	15–40	2.1	0.2
mantle lithosphere	40+	3.5	0.02

Complete the table below. At each step, $q(z) = q(z_{\text{prev}}) - A \cdot \Delta z$, using the A of whichever layer that step falls in. The first step is worked for you.

z km	Layer	Δz km	$A \cdot \Delta z$ mW m^{-2}	$q(z)$ mW m^{-2}
0	–	–	–	60.0
5	upper crust	5	7.5	52.5
10	upper crust	5		
15	upper crust	5		
40	lower crust	25		
80	upper mantle	20		
100	upper mantle	20		

Question 3. Stage 2: Building $T(z)$

Now use your completed $q(z)$ column. Within each step, q varies linearly, so the exact temperature rise across that step is the *average* of q at the two ends, divided by k , times Δz : $\Delta T = \frac{q(z_{\text{prev}}) + q(z)}{2k} \Delta z$. The first step is worked for you.

z km	$q(z)$ mW m^{-2}	k $\text{W m}^{-1} \text{K}^{-1}$	Δz km	ΔT K	$T(z)$ $^{\circ}\text{C}$
0	60.0	—	—	—	15.0
5	52.5	3.0	5	93.75	108.75
10		3.0	5		
15		3.0	5		
40		2.1	25		
80		2.1	20		
100		2.1	20		

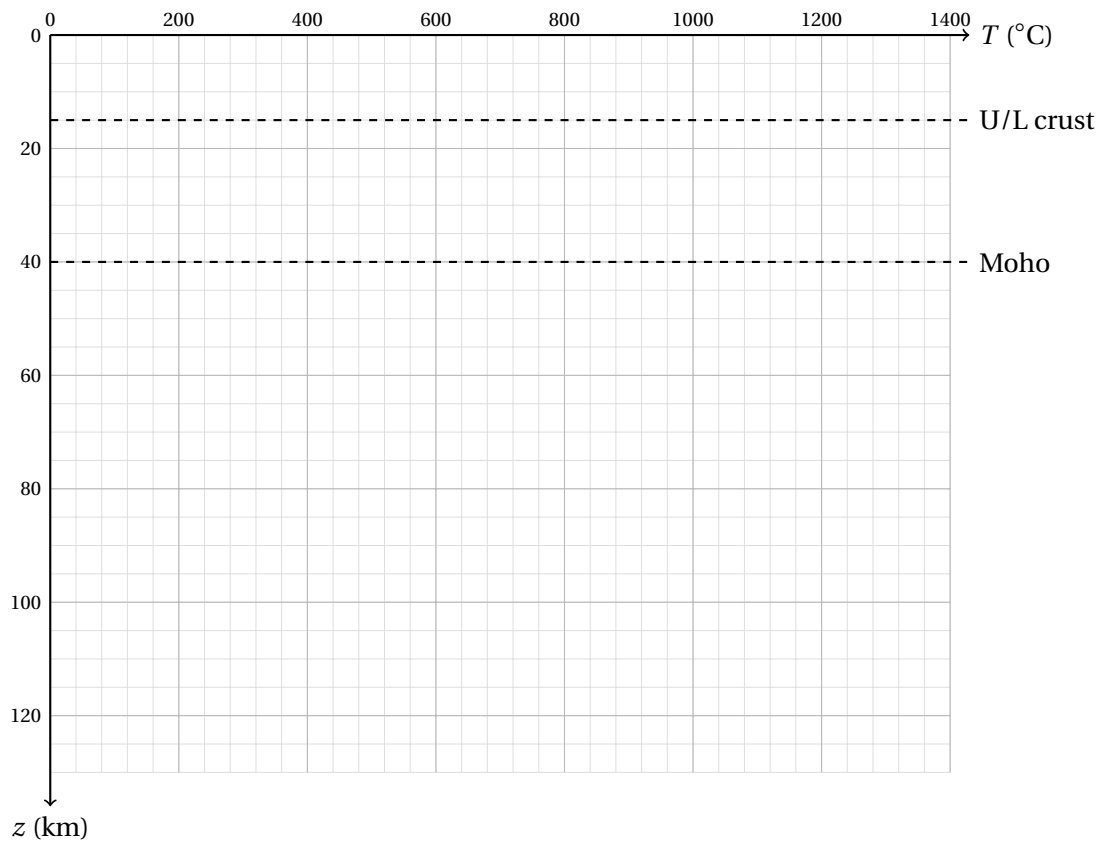
Your $z = 35$ result is the Moho temperature.

Given, since it would take too many additional steps to compute by hand: continuing this same method through the mantle lithosphere, the geotherm meets the adiabat at $z \approx 116$ km, $T \approx 1335^{\circ}\text{C}$. Because A is so small there, the mantle segment is very close to a straight line.

Question 4. Plotting the Geotherm

Plot your Stage 2 results along with the table below and draw a curve through the dots. Also plot the mantle adiabat $T = 1300 + 0.3z$ (two points are enough — it's a straight line).

z_i km	Layer	$q(z_i)$ mW m^{-2}	$T(z_i)$ $^{\circ}\text{C}$
20	lower crust	36.5	347
25	lower crust	35.5	433
30	lower crust	34.5	516
35	lower crust	33.5	597
50	mantle lithosphere	32.3	768
60	mantle lithosphere	32.1	860
70	mantle lithosphere	31.9	951
90	mantle lithosphere	31.5	1133
100	mantle lithosphere	31.3	1222
110	mantle lithosphere	31.1	1311



- (a) Where is curvature most visible on your plot – and where is the curve closest to a straight line? Does that match which layers have the largest A ?

- (b) What does the depth where your geotherm meets the adiabat physically represent?

Question 5. Changing k

Recompute *only* $T(z)$ (not $q(z)$ – nothing about it has changed) at $z = 5, 10, 15$, using $k'_1 = 1.5 \text{ W m}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$ for the upper crust instead of 3.0.

z km	$q(z)$ mW m^{-1}	k'_1 $\text{W m}^{-1} \text{K}^{-1}$	Δz km	$T(z)$ $^{\circ}\text{C}$
0	60.0	–	–	15.0
5		1.5	5	
10		1.5	5	
15		1.5	5	

Question 6. Changing A

Now recompute *both* $q(z)$ and $T(z)$ at $z = 5, 10, 15$, using $A'_1 = 3.0 \mu\text{W m}^{-3}$ for the upper crust instead of 1.5 (keep $k_1 = 3.0$).

z km	Layer	Δz km	$A \cdot \Delta z$ mW m^{-2}	$q(z)$ mW m^{-2}	k $\text{W m}^{-1} \text{K}^{-1}$	$T(z)$ $^{\circ}\text{C}$
0	–	–	–	60.0	–	0.0
5	Upper crust	5			3.0	
10	Upper crust	5			3.0	
15	Upper crust	5			3.0	

Question 7. Contemplate, Then Check

- (a) If the k change in Question 5 persisted through the whole column, would you expect the Moho temperature and the lithosphere thickness (adiabat-crossing depth) to increase or decrease relative to the base case? Explain your reasoning before looking below.

- (b) Now do the same for the A change in Question 6 – predict the direction *before* checking.

- (c) **Reveal:** continuing each perturbation through the full column gives:

	Moho temperature ($^{\circ}\text{C}$)	Adiabat crossing (km)
Base case	582	116
$k'_1 = 1.5$ (halved)	826	88
$A'_1 = 3.0$ (doubled)	311	never, within any plausible depth

Was your prediction for the A case right? If not, what does doubling A_1 actually do to $q(z)$ everywhere below 15 km, and why does that matter more than the extra heat generated in the upper 15 km itself? And now that you've seen a geotherm that never reaches the adiabat at all – what would that actually mean, physically, if it were real?

Key Ideas

$q(z)$ and $T(z)$ depend on different things, and in a specific order. $q(z)$ is fixed entirely by $A(z)$ and q_0 – conductivity and temperature never enter into it. $T(z)$ needs $q(z)$ as an input, so it cannot be built first. Doing every layer's q before starting on any layer's T is not just tidier bookkeeping; it reflects a genuine one-way dependency.

Where a geotherm meets the mantle adiabat marks the base of the thermal lithosphere. Below that depth, material follows the adiabat because it convects; above it, conduction controls the temperature profile.

Conductivity changes the gradient without changing $q(z)$; heat production changes both. A conductivity change reshapes $T(z)$ but leaves $q(z)$ untouched. A heat-production change reshapes $q(z)$ itself – and because $T(z)$ is built from $q(z)$, its effects propagate to every layer below, not just the one where A changed.

A geotherm that never reaches the adiabat is telling you something is wrong with the inputs, not that convection has stopped. You saw this directly in Question 7: doubling A_1 alone was enough to push the crossing beyond any depth the model should be trusted at. If heat production genuinely stayed that high all the way down in the real Earth, the honest reading is not "no convection, cold interior" as a stable outcome – it's that $A(z)$ cannot actually behave that way at depth, because the mantle demonstrably does convect almost everywhere. The model breaking is the useful result.

Whether more heat production means a hotter or colder interior depends entirely on which boundary condition is fixed. With q_0 fixed – what you actually measure at surface – concentrating heat production near the surface lets that heat escape quickly, without needing to warm the material beneath it much at all; burying the same heat production deeper means it has to slowly work its way up through everything above it, warming the interior as it goes. (This is a spatial statement about a steady-state solution, not a claim about anything happening over time – but it is easy to accidentally hear it as one, so it is worth restating carefully.) Hold the *basal* heat flow fixed instead, and adding crustal heat production genuinely adds heat on top of an unchanged supply – temperatures rise. Same physics, opposite-sounding conclusion, depending only on which end of the profile you treat as given. This is a real source of confusion even among practising geophysicists – and it is the reason a region like South Australia can show active-tectonic-like heat flow (90+ mW/m²) despite a thick lithosphere more typical of stable, early Proterozoic terranes elsewhere: not young, active tectonics, but unusually high crustal radiogenic heat production riding on an otherwise unremarkable deep thermal state.